THE BATTLE OF NAULOCHUS

In the course of the civil wars that succeeded the assassination of Julius Caesar in 44 BCE, Sextus Pompeius, son of Pompey the Great, attempted to grab a share of the spoils. In command of the Roman fleet, he captured Sicily, a vital source of grain supplies. Octavian, a member of Rome's ruling triumvirate, entrusted Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa with creating a fleet to retake Sicily.

Agrippa established a naval base, Portus Julius, near modern-day Naples. There he built ships and trained their crews in the latest fighting techniques. They learned to use not only the rock-hurling artillery now standard upon warships, but also a new device known as the arpax, a catapult that projected grappling irons onto an enemy galley. Agrippa also had his ships' hulls reinforced with beams around the waterline to resist ramming.

THE POMPEIANS CRUSHED

In summer 36 BCE, Octavian launched an invasion of Sicily with armies from Italy and North Africa. Agrippa, who was to cover the movement of troops and keep their supply lines open, moved to a forward base on the Lipari islands. From there he made a successful but inconclusive attack on part of Sextus's fleet at Mylae. Sextus then sent his entire naval force to confront Agrippa in a desperate bid to regain command of the sea, which alone offered him a chance of resisting Octavian's invasion.

Almost equal in number, the two forces approached each other in line abreast along the Sicilian coast. Agrippa's ships were, however, slightly more widely spaced. This enabled them to turn Sextus's flank on the seaward side and press their enemy in to the shore. As the battle developed into a close-packed mêlée, Agrippa's well-trained force gained the upper hand. His archers, mounted on towers, shot fire arrows down onto the enemy. His catapults battered hulls and carved deadly paths through crowded decks. The arpax allowed his men to grapple and board ships weakened by the missile barrage.

When the fighting stopped, 28 of Sextus's ships had been sunk and almost all the rest had been captured. Only 17 ships escaped out of a fleet of around 300 vessels. Sicily fell to Octavian. Sextus slipped away to the east, but the following year fell into the hands of one of Mark Antony's followers and was summarily executed.

ROMAN CIVIL WARS



BATTLE OF NAULOCHUS

Date	September 3, 36 BCE
Location	Off north coast of Sicily
Result	Crushing victory for Octavian

COMBATANTS

OCTAVIAN	SEXTUS POMPEIUS

COMMANDERS

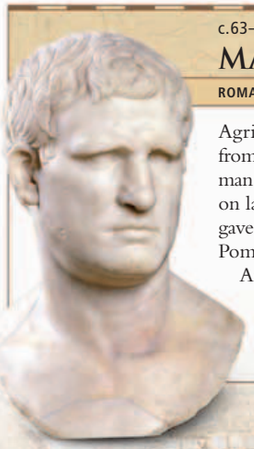
Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa	Sextus Pompeius

FORCES

Ships: c.300	**Ships:** c.300

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** 3	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** 28 sunk, c.255 captured



c.63–12 BCE

MARCUS VIPSANIUS AGRIPPA

ROMAN NAVAL COMMANDER

Agrippa was a friend of Julius Caesar's adopted son Octavian from childhood, and became the future emperor's right-hand man during his rise to power. He made a reputation as a general on land before, in 37 BCE, Octavian made him consul and gave him responsibility for creating a fleet to defeat Sextus Pompeius. His victories over Sextus at Naulochus and Mark Antony at Actium showed a firm grasp of naval tactics as well as great powers of organization and leadership. Much of his later life was spent on campaign in Gaul, Spain, Germany, and Rome's eastern provinces.



Mosaic of Roman war galley
The mosaic shows the helmsman in the stern, the commander standing in the galley's bow, and armed soldiers ready to board an enemy ship.